Admiralty, May 7, 1897.

DESPATCHES, of which the following are copies, have been received from Rear-Admiral Harry H. Rawson, C.B., Commander-in-Chief on the Cape of Good Hope and West Coast of Africa Station, reporting operations against the King of Benin, and the capture of Benin City.

H.M.S. "St. George," at Forcados.

The London Gazette, 7 May 1897

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Rear-Admiral Rawson's despatches on 'operations against the King of Benin, and the capture of Benin City', printed in the government's official newspaper. The report of the column's commander (right) describes the palace altars, 'carved ivory tusks' set in 'brass heads', and the fire that 'destroyed the King's and all surrounding quarters'.

> The official record describes the objects. It does not say that they were taken, or where they went next.

earthen (clay) sacrificial altar about 50 feet long close against the wall on which were placed the gods to whom sacrifice was made—mostly being carved ivory tusks, standing upright, mounted at base, in hideously-constructed brass heads. In front of each ivory god was a small earthen mound on which the victim's forehead would apparently be placed. The altars were covered with streams of dried human blood, and the stench was too frightful.

It would seem that the populace sat around in these huge compounds while the Ju Ju priests performed the sacrifices for their edification. In the various sacrifice compounds were found open pits filled with human bodies giving forth most trying odours. The first night several cases of fainting and sickness occurred owing to the stench, which was equally bad everywhere.

In one of the pits, partially under other bodies, was found a victim, still living, who, being rescued, turned out to be a servant of Mr. Gordon's, one of the members of Mr. Phillips' ill-fated expedition. At the doors and gates of houses and compounds were stinking goats and fowls, sacrificed apparently to prevent the white man entering therein.

The foregoing is but a feeble attempt to describe the house of this most terrible city, which, after five days' continuous fatigue working with about 1,000 natives, still presents most appalling and frightful sights. In the outlying parts of the city the same sights are met, and the annual expenditure of human life in sacrifice must have been enormous.

Most of the wells were also found filled with human bodies. Goats and fowls were also used for sacrifice, and for the latter elaborate altars with two bronze cocks on each were found erected.

On the 19th three Jekris of the ill-fated expe-

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